

YOUR CALL IS IMPORTANT

a short film

Blue Sheep Films

working draft v1.1

INT. OWEN'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - MORNING

A wall calendar says SATURDAY in the way only a calendar over a kitchen table can. Coffee brews. Sunlight. A whole day, wide open.

OWEN (26) sits at the table in weekend clothes, fed, caffeinated, prepared. Before him, arranged like a legal exhibit: a BILL with one line highlighted in furious yellow, a RETURN RECEIPT, and a phone.

The highlighted line: EQUIPMENT NON-RETURN FEE — \$740.00.

The receipt: RETURNED — 1 MODEM. Stamped. Dated. Signed by a human named "Chad B."

OWEN
(to the receipt, gently)
We have them.

He dials. Speakerphone. It rings once.

AUTOMATED VOICE (V.O.)
(warm, infinite)
Thank you for calling. Your call
is important to us.

MAIN TITLE: YOUR CALL IS IMPORTANT

INT. OWEN'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - MORNING

AUTOMATED VOICE (V.O.)
Please listen carefully, as our
menu options have recently
changed.

OWEN
They always say that. They've
been saying that since I was
nine.

AUTOMATED VOICE (V.O.)
For billing, say "billing."

OWEN
Billing.

AUTOMATED VOICE (V.O.)
I heard: "cancel service." Are
you sure you want to cancel?

OWEN
No — billing. BILL-ING.

AUTOMATED VOICE (V.O.)
Great. Transferring you to our
cancellations team.

OWEN
No—!

CLICK. New hold music begins: a smooth-jazz arrangement of
a song that was already bad.

Owen looks at the ceiling. The ceiling offers nothing.

INT. OWEN'S APARTMENT - VARIOUS - MORNING - SERIES

The hold music continues. Under it:

- Owen, phone on speaker on the counter, unloads the
dishwasher. Every clink careful, like the call might hear.

- Owen does push-ups beside the phone. The music does not
acknowledge his growth.

- Owen holds the phone to the window, as if reception were
the problem. Reception is not the problem. Nothing is the
problem. That's the problem.

HOLD SYSTEM (V.O.)
You are caller number...
seventeen... in the queue.

OWEN
Seventeen.

He writes 17 on the corner of the bill. Underlines it.
A man now keeping records.

INT. OWEN'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - LATE MORNING

HOLD SYSTEM (V.O.)
You are caller number... nine...
in the queue. Did you know you
can resolve most issues at our
website?

OWEN
The website told me to call. You
told me to call. It's a circle.
You built a circle.

HOLD SYSTEM (V.O.)
Your approximate wait time is...
twenty... minutes.

OWEN
You said that an hour ago. Time
doesn't work in here, does it?
You're not measuring anything.
You're just saying numbers to
keep morale up.

The hold music swells slightly, as if flattered.

A KNOCK at the door. Owen freezes – looks at the phone –
carries it with him like a newborn.

At the door: his neighbour, RAJ (30s), holding a parcel.

RAJ
This came for you Thursday–

OWEN
(whispering)
I'm on hold.

RAJ
(whispering back,
instantly complicit)
Who?

OWEN
(whispering)
The internet people. Seven
hundred and forty dollars. For a
modem I returned.

Raj inhales through his teeth – the universal sound of a
man who has seen combat.

RAJ
(whispering)
I did six hours with the airline
in March. Stay hydrated. Don't
take the callback. The callback
is a trap.

He sets the parcel down like a wreath and withdraws.

INT. OWEN'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - EARLY AFTERNOON

HOLD SYSTEM (V.O.)
Rather than waiting, you can
receive a callback when an agent
is available. Press one to hold
your place in line.

Owen's finger hovers. Raj's warning hangs in the air. The
callback is a trap.

But he's weak. He's four hours in. He presses one.

HOLD SYSTEM (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Great. We'll call you back. You
may hang up now.

Silence. Real silence, for the first time in hours. It's deafening. Owen sets the phone down and backs away from it slowly, a bomb tech leaving the site.

INT. OWEN'S APARTMENT - BATHROOM - AFTERNOON

Owen, finally, in the shower. Steam. Peace. Water pressure absolving him of the day so far.

The phone – balanced on the sink in a DRY GLASS, screen up, volume maxed – RINGS.

OWEN
NO—

Chaos. Elbows. Shampoo. He gets a towel half on and lunges – swipes with a wet thumb – the wet thumb doesn't register – swipes – SWIPES—

OWEN (CONT'D)
I'm here! Hello! I'm here—

AUTOMATED VOICE (V.O.)
We called with an update. Good
news: your case is still open.
Goodbye.

CLICK.

Owen stands dripping in the doorway, towel at half-mast, betrayed in his own home.

OWEN
(quiet, biblical)
The callback is a trap.

INT. OWEN'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - AFTERNOON

Redial. Menu tree. He speaks in the flat, over-enunciated dialect of the veteran:

OWEN
Billing. BILLING. Representative.
Agent. Human. Person. HUMAN
PERSON—

AUTOMATED VOICE (V.O.)
Okay! Connecting you to an agent.

Ringling. An answer – a HUMAN – DALE (V.O.), chipper.

DALE (V.O.)
Thanks for holding! Can I start
with your account number, name,
address, and the last four
digits of–

OWEN
Yes – 4-4-0-9-1-1-2. Owen Tran.
Fifty-five Marchmount, unit two.
Six-six-two-one. The charge is
wrong, I returned the modem, I
have the receipt, a man named
Chad signed it–

DALE (V.O.)
Oh, I see it. Yeah, that's a
billing dispute. This is
technical support.

OWEN
The machine sent me here.

DALE (V.O.)
It does that.
(already transferring)
I'll get you right over – stay
on the line – and there might be
a short verification–

OWEN
Dale. Dale, will they have my
information, or will I have to
say it all again – Dale? DALE?

Hold music. A new arrangement. Somehow smugger.

NEW AGENT (V.O.)
(eventually)
Thanks for holding! Can I start
with your account number, name,
address–

Owen lays his forehead down on the kitchen table with great
care, like something fragile being returned to its box.

INT. OWEN'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - EVENING

Golden hour. The Saturday is dying outside the window,
beautifully, without him.

The bill has notes all over it now. Names, times, badge numbers. GAVIN 2:12. PRIYA 3:40 – "escalated." DALE (DO NOT TRUST). Owen has a blanket over his shoulders. The posture of a man at hour nine of a war of attrition.

HOLD SYSTEM (V.O.)
You are caller number... two...
in the queue.

Owen doesn't react. He's been number two before. Number two is where hope goes to die.

Then – a click. A voice. Older. Unhurried. Tired in a way that matches his.

DENISE (V.O.)
Retention and resolutions, this
is Denise. I've got your file up,
Mr. Tran – don't say the account
number again. I can see they've
made you say it six times.

Owen sits up slowly. Blanket falls.

OWEN
You can see that?

DENISE (V.O.)
I can see everything, hon. It's
all in the notes. You've been at
this since nine-oh-two this
morning.

(keys clicking)
Modem, returned March eleventh,
receipt on file... yeah. This is
our error. Watch the screen.

OWEN
Watch the—

DENISE (V.O.)
Refresh your account page.

He does. The \$740 line item – vanishes. Just gone. Nine hours, and the actual repair takes her ninety seconds and four keystrokes.

OWEN
It's gone.

DENISE (V.O.)
Reversed, confirmation email's
on its way, case closed. Anything
else?

And here it is: the speech. He's rehearsed it since 9:02 AM – the corporate negligence, the circle they built, the theft of a Saturday, the CALLBACK. He has it loaded. He takes the breath–

– and what comes out is:

OWEN
How long have you been on today?

Pause. Keys stop clicking.

DENISE (V.O.)
Hour ten. I'm the last skill level, hon. By the time a call gets to me, somebody's been bounced around all day and they're ready to bite. That's the job. I catch what the maze spits out.

OWEN
That's a horrible job.

DENISE (V.O.)
It's a job. My headset's decent and the maze isn't my fault.
(beat)
You know you're the first person today who asked me anything? And the only one who said – actually, you haven't said it yet.

OWEN
Thank you. Denise. Sincerely.

DENISE (V.O.)
There it is.
(a smile in it)
Enjoy what's left of your Saturday, Mr. Tran.

CLICK.

INT. OWEN'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Silence.

Real, total, case-closed silence. Owen sits in it.

He won. The proof is on the screen. The Saturday is gone, the money is back, the file is closed, and the apartment is so quiet it rings.

He looks at the phone. Nine hours of hold music, and now that it's gone the room feels — evacuated. He drums his fingers once, twice, in the rhythm of the smooth-jazz song he will now know forever.

He puts the kettle on, just for the noise.

And then — the phone RINGS. He looks: the screen says the company's name. The callback. The morning's callback, arriving at last, hours after the war is over, faithful as a dog crossing a country to find a family that moved.

Owen looks at it ring.

And lets it.

It rings out. The kettle starts to murmur. He turns off the kitchen light.

AUTOMATED VOICE (V.O.)
(from the dark, to no
one, leaving a
voicemail)

We called with an update. Good
news—

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END